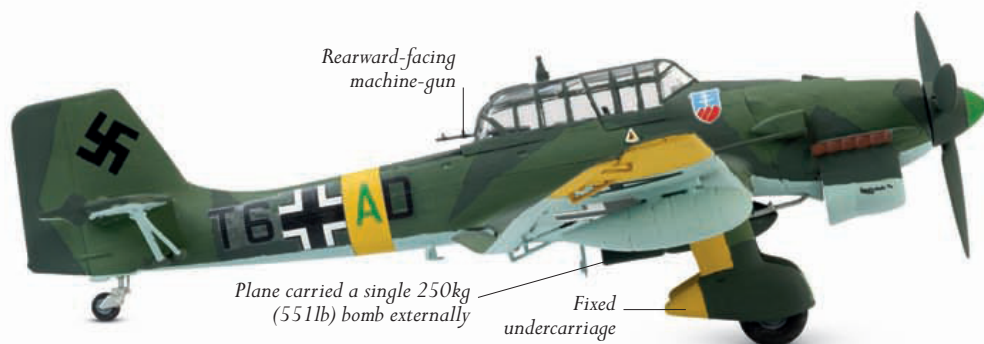


BOMBER AIRCRAFT 1943-45

Strategic bombers evolved during the course of World War II, their capacities enhanced by the development of more powerful engines, and their capabilities improved by the introduction of radar-based guidance systems and the first effective predictive bombsights. By 1944, the best of these could deliver heavy bomb loads with great accuracy onto targets thousands of miles from their home bases, but they were still sustaining major losses – the British Royal Air Force (RAF) Bomber Command alone lost over 12,000 aircraft during the course of the war.



▲ JUNKERS JU 87D STUKA

Date 1941 **Origin** Germany

Wingspan 13.8m (45½ft)

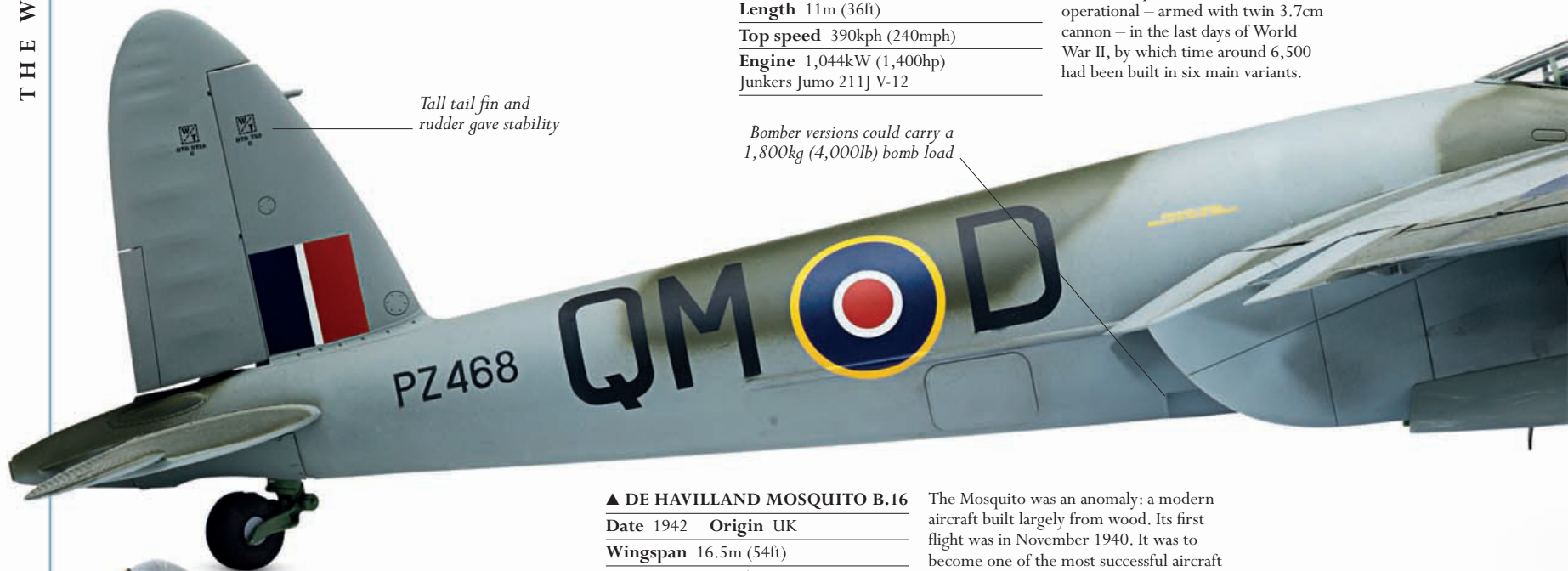
Length 11m (36ft)

Top speed 390kph (240mph)

Engine 1,044kW (1,400hp)
Junkers Jumo 211J V-12

Perhaps the most recognizable of all German aircraft of the period, the Ju 87 *Sturzkampfflugzeug* first saw combat in Spain, in 1937. It was still operational – armed with twin 3.7cm cannon – in the last days of World War II, by which time around 6,500 had been built in six main variants.

Bomber versions could carry a 1,800kg (4,000lb) bomb load



▲ DE HAVILLAND MOSQUITO B.16

Date 1942 **Origin** UK

Wingspan 16.5m (54ft)

Length 12.6m (41½ft)

Top speed 670kph (415mph)

Engine Two 1,275kW (1,710hp)
Rolls-Royce Merlin 76 V-12s

The Mosquito was an anomaly: a modern aircraft built largely from wood. Its first flight was in November 1940. It was to become one of the most successful aircraft the British RAF operated during World War II, serving in bomber, day- and night-fighter, and reconnaissance roles.



◀ MARTIN B-26 MARAUDER

Date 1942 **Origin** US

Wingspan 21.65m (71ft)

Length 17.8m (58¼ft)

Top speed 460kph (290mph)

Engine Two 1,417kW (1,900hp)
Pratt & Whitney R-2800-43
Double Wasp radials

The Marauder was designed and operated as a medium bomber. It saw service in the Pacific Theatre, Europe, and the Mediterranean. Despite being difficult to fly and having stability problems early on, due to a poorly designed fin, it ended the war with the lowest loss rate of any US Army Air Force aircraft.

▼ HEINKEL HE 177 GRIEF

Date 1942 **Origin** Germany

Wingspan 31.45m (103ft)

Length 22m (72¼ft)

Top speed 565kph (350mph)

Engine Two 1,939kW (2,600hp)
Daimler-Benz DB 610 W-24s

The *Grief* (Griffin) was the only purpose-built long-range heavy bomber operated by the *Luftwaffe* during World War II. An inspired design that was flawed in execution, many of its shortcomings could be traced to its over-complicated engine and to the requirement that it function as a precision dive bomber.



Two .5in machine-guns

